AI Design Workflow System

Team Onboarding Guide

How to use the 7-file system that powers every project

What This System Is

This is a shared AI design workflow system — seven markdown files that live inside Claude and act as a collective second brain for every project we work on. Instead of each person starting from scratch, we all start from the same strong foundation.

The system covers the full design process: from framing research and writing prompts, to prototyping, testing, handing off, and pitching. Every file is tuned to our actual tool stack.

> These are not rigid rules — they are starting points. Adapt any template, prompt, or checklist to fit the project.

File Order — When to Use What

The 7 files operate in three distinct modes. This is the most important thing to understand about the system.

#	File	Purpose	When to Use
	ONCE ONLY — Setup	**Load these first. Revisit only if your role or stack changes.**	
1	**claude.md**	Master profile — tells Claude who we are, our stack, and how to respond	Load into every Claude Project on first setup
2	**skills.md**	Quick-reference index — maps any task to the right file and tool	Read once during setup. Return when unsure where to go.

#	File	Purpose	When to Use
	EVERY SESSION — Without Fail	**Do this at the start of every single Claude conversation.**	
3	**context.md**	Project kickstart template — fills Claude in on the current project and session	Paste at the start of every session. No exceptions.
	BY PROJECT PHASE — In Order	**Follow the shape of the project from kickoff to delivery.**	
4	**design.md**	Phase-by-phase design process with AI prompts at each step	Open at Phase 0. Return at the start of each new phase.
5	**research.md**	Full research workflow from brief to stakeholder readout	Runs parallel to phases 1–2. Any research or synthesis task.
6	**prompts.md**	Ready-to-use prompt library organized by task type	Throughout the entire project. Check before writing any prompt.
7	**handoff.md**	Dev handoff, research readouts, design rationale, Figma standards	End of each phase. Before closing any deliverable.
8	**pitch.md**	Value proposition, pitch deck, ROI, and business case frameworks	Near end of project, or mid-stream when a business case is needed.

> The simplest rule: claude.md once, context.md always, the rest follow the shape of the project.

One-Time Setup

Do this once. After that, the system travels with you into every project.

1 **Add all 7 files to your Claude Project**
In Claude.ai, open your Project → click “Project Knowledge” → upload all 7 .md files. Claude will read them automatically in every conversation within that project.

2 **Read through skills.md once**
Spend 5 minutes scanning the quick-reference decision matrix and tool selection guide. You don’t need to memorize it — just know it’s there.

3 **Verify Claude has read the files**

Start a new conversation and type: “What files do you have loaded and what does each one cover?” Claude should describe all 7 files accurately.

4

Bookmark context.md locally

Keep context.md somewhere easy to find — Notion, desktop, or downloads folder. You’ll fill it out and paste it at the start of every session.

5

Do a test run

Pick a real task — framing a research brief, writing a prompt, or drafting a handoff note — and run it through the system before using it on a live project.

How to Start Every Session

Follow this sequence at the beginning of any new Claude conversation for a project.

1

Open Claude inside your Project

Make sure you’re inside the Project that has your 7 files loaded — not a general Claude conversation.

2

Fill out context.md

Open your saved copy of context.md. Fill in every bracketed field: project name, user, business goal, current stage, what you need today, and which tools are in use. Takes 2–3 minutes.

3

Paste the completed context.md into Claude

Paste the whole filled-in file as your first message. Claude will calibrate everything that follows to your specific situation.

4

Give Claude your task

Be specific. “Draft a research brief” is okay. “Use the research brief framework to draft questions for 45-minute interviews with mid-career fitness app users” is better.

Quick session? Use the stripped-down 6-line version at the bottom of context.md. Same principle — less typing.

Using Each File

Documented in the order you'll use them: setup first, then every-session, then by project phase.

1. claude.md — Your Profile · Load Once

Background context Claude reads automatically. It tells Claude who you are, your tool stack, your communication preferences, and where you need the most support. You don't interact with it directly.

> If your tool stack or role changes, update claude.md. It shapes every response Claude gives you.

2. skills.md — The Index · Read Once, Reference Always

Your decision map. Read through once during setup. After that, return whenever you're not sure which file to open or which tool to use.

- Quick-reference decision matrix: task → file
- Tool selection guide: Figma Make vs Stitch vs Claude vs Antigravity
- Descriptions of what's inside each of the 7 files

3. context.md — Project Kickstart · Every Session Without Fail

The highest-frequency file in the system. Fill it out and paste it at the start of every single session. It prevents generic advice and forces you to be clear about what you need before typing a single prompt.

- Full version: use at the start of any new project or phase
- Short version (6 lines): use for quick follow-up sessions on an existing project

4. design.md — The Design Process · Phase by Phase

The full phase-by-phase design process with AI integration at every step. Open it at the start of a new project (Phase 0) and return each time you move into a new phase.

- Phase 0: Project kickstart and brief
- Phase 1: Discovery and research
- Phase 2: Define and synthesize
- Phase 3: Ideation — includes AI ethics checklist for AI-powered features
- Phase 4: Prototyping with Stitch and Figma Make prompt templates
- Phase 5: User testing

- Phase 6: Iteration and handoff

5. research.md — User Research · Parallel to Phases 1–2

The complete research workflow from writing the brief to delivering findings. Runs alongside design.md phases 1–2. Use it any time you're running interviews, surveys, synthesis, or usability tests.

- Research brief template and sharpener prompt
- Screener survey generator and sample size quick reference
- Interview guide generator and transcription best practices
- Rapid synthesis and multi-session synthesis prompts
- Insight-to-action table and executive summary generator

> Always remove PII from transcripts before pasting them into any AI tool for analysis.

6. prompts.md — The Prompt Library · Throughout the Entire Project

Not sequential — a reference you dip into constantly. Before writing any AI prompt from scratch, check here first and customize a template.

- Section 1: Research briefs and competitive analysis
- Section 2: Personas and journey maps
- Section 3: Ideation and feature prioritization
- Section 4: Stitch and Figma Make screen generation
- Section 5: Microcopy — onboarding, errors, CTAs, empty states
- Section 6: Flow optimization and screen audits
- Section 7: Research synthesis
- Section 8: Stakeholder communication
- Section 9: Antigravity — Google Workspace-integrated research prompts

The Prompt Log at the bottom is your personal space. Add any prompt you've tested and want to reuse.

7. handoff.md — Closing the Loop · End of Each Phase

Everything needed to close a project phase cleanly. Use it at the end of each phase — not just the final delivery.

- Developer handoff checklist: screens, states, components, accessibility
- Annotation and interaction spec generators
- Research readout structure and executive summary prompt

- Design rationale template
- Stakeholder presentation structure
- Figma file organization standard and naming conventions

8. pitch.md — Business Case & Pitch · Near End, or When Needed

For translating design into business language. Usually near the end of a project, but pull it in earlier any time you need to justify a direction or build a business case mid-stream.

- Value Proposition Canvas with AI prompts for each section
- 10-slide pitch deck structure with narrative generator
- ROI framework — maps design decisions to business metrics
- Gamma.app workflow for fast deck creation
- Internal AI tool advocacy pitch template

Best Practices for the Team

Always paste context.md first

No exceptions. Even a 2-minute fill-in gets you dramatically better output than starting cold. It's the highest-ROI habit in the system.

Be specific in your prompts

Generic input produces generic output. The more context you give — user type, product name, business goal, constraints — the more actionable the result.

Use the '80% there' principle

AI output is a strong first draft, not a final deliverable. Expect to spend 20% of your time refining. Don't wait for perfect prompts — iterate quickly.

Log prompts that work

When a prompt produces a great result, add it to the Prompt Log at the bottom of prompts.md with a note on what made it work. Over time this becomes one of the most valuable parts of the system.

Run the AI ethics checklist on any AI feature

Before prototyping any feature that uses AI to make decisions, run the Designing for Trust checklist in design.md. It takes 5 minutes and prevents expensive fixes later.

Keep the files updated

If your tool stack changes, update claude.md. If a process works better than what's documented, update the relevant file. The system is only as useful as it is current.

Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
Claude gives generic advice	Check you're inside the correct Claude Project with files loaded. Paste context.md at the start of the conversation.
Not sure which file to open	Open skills.md and use the quick-reference decision matrix. Or check the File Order table on page 2.
Output doesn't match my tool	Go to prompts.md and use the tool-specific section: Section 4 for Stitch/Figma Make, Section 9 for Antigravity.
The prompt worked but needs refinement	That's normal. Run a second prompt with more specific constraints, or tell Claude exactly what to change.
A file feels out of date	Adapt it. The files are starting points. Modify any section to fit the work.

Questions? Update a file. Found a better prompt? Log it. The system improves with use.